

Assignment 1: Societal Problem Definition

Societal problem: Stray Animal Welfare & Shelter Management

Manx animal charity warns it is 'at capacity'

23 August 2026



BBC

Krish Boruch said the charity has seen a "massive increase" in animals needing rehoming

The Manx SPCA said its kennels and cattery are full and it is now asking the public to help find homes for the animals in its care.

The charity said it had seen a "massive increase" in cats, dogs and kittens needing rehoming this summer, more than in previous years.

Krish Boruch, who dedicates all her time to the care of the animals, is now urging people thinking of getting a pet to adopt rather than buy cheaply advertised animals on social media.

"Our aim is always to find a cat or a dog that fits that person, and never to mould an animal," she said.

This news article was written by Josh Cann and published on 23-08-2026 in BBC News (Isle of Man), which is a British public service broadcaster.

The societal challenge in this news article is the surge of animals in the animal centers in the United Kingdom. In the Manx animal charity there has been a recent increase in animals, as a result of which the kennels and cattery are full and the charity can't take any more animals in their care. One of the reasons there is an increase according to the Manx animal charity is because there have been more people that advertise their pets online on Facebook Marketplace. Most of these pets haven't been health checked and are very ill. When people buy these pets, they can't afford the treatment some of these pets need and therefore they have been giving pets away to the charity. The consequences of these animals staying longer in shelters causes behavioural issues with the animals, and some stray animals will get turned away because there is no capacity left in the shelters.

We are mostly interested in this topic because we share a concern for animal welfare and some of us also own pets. Furthermore, seeing a lot of related content made us realize that many shelters are at its capacity and that it creates many issues that need to be dealt with. We want to know why many animals end up in shelters and what we, or people in general, can do to help.

This challenge is relevant for animals, pet owners, potential adopters, animal shelters, animal rescue organizations, and veterinarians.

Scientific peer-reviewed articles

We have chosen three articles that focus on different aspects of the challenge of animal shelter overcrowding. The first article (Applebaum et al., 2024) is about the causes of animal relinquishment, the second article (Raudies et al., 2021) discusses the consequences of animals staying in animal shelters for a long time, and the last article (Hurley, 2022) considers the possible strategies to improve animal shelter outcomes.

The first article is relevant for our challenge because it explains how housing-related problems can be a cause of animal relinquishment. Researchers investigated these problems using intake data from 21 U.S. animal shelters between 2019 and 2023. They found that housing issues accounted for approximately 14% of all intakes in their dataset. These issues included pet restrictions, landlord issues, loss of housing, and being unhoused. When many animals get relinquished, shelters can become overcrowded, which can lead to a lack of space and resources to properly care for every animal in the shelter.

The second article investigates the issues dogs develop when staying in a shelter for longer than five months. The conclusion of this article was that most of these dogs are more sensitive to stressors, leading to behavioural issues and difficulties to relax in the shelter environment. This is relevant for the challenge because this is one of the core reasons that animal shelters have a constrained capacity. The longer a dog stays in a shelter, the more sensitive it becomes to stress, making adoption significantly less likely.

The last article directly addresses the issue with admitting animals on an unscheduled basis without prior assessment of animal need. The author highlights the consequences of unmanaged admissions including animal overcrowding, elevated animal stress, disease transmission, decreased effectiveness and more. The article presents triage and appointment-based services as a technique used in human healthcare, to address the previously stated issues. The reported

positive results and trends demonstrate that this approach improves animal shelter outcomes. This article is relevant because it shows that with the triage and appointment-based care approach the problems with animal shelters such as overcrowding can be addressed and the situation can be improved.

Subtypes of the scientific articles

The first article (Applebaum et al., 2024) is an original article because it uses collected data from 21 animal shelters across the United States. The same goes for the second article (Raudies et al., 2021), which collected and analyzed data on shelter dogs to examine their welfare, making it an original article as well. Unlike the first two, the last article (Hurley, 2022) is a perspective article that discusses different strategies for reducing and managing shelter intake while improving animal welfare.

References

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- Cann, J. (2026, August 23). *Manx SPCA animal charity “at capacity” and appeals for adopters*. <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cx2regj7977o>
- Hurley, K. F. (2022). The evolving role of triage and Appointment-Based admission to improve service, care and outcomes in animal shelters. *Frontiers in Veterinary Science*, 9, 809340. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fvets.2022.809340>
- Raudies, C., Waiblinger, S., & Arhant, C. (2021). Characteristics and welfare of Long-Term Shelter Dogs. *Animals*, 11(1), 194. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ani11010194>